

To dominate the market, you cannot just cater to Amazon KDP. While Amazon owns ~80% of the eBook market, **IngramSpark** controls the global distribution to libraries, independent bookstores, and big retailers like Barnes & Noble and Waterstones.

If you ignore IngramSpark, your authors cannot get into physical bookstores.

Here is the "**Universal Publishing Strategy**" covering the remaining giants (IngramSpark, Lulu, Barnes & Noble) and the technical traps they set.

1. The "Big Three" Competitors (And Their Traps)

Platform	The "Trap"	The PagePerfect Fix
IngramSpark	Strict Color profiles. They will reject files with "Rich Black" text (CMYK 60/40/40/100) on cream paper because it bleeds.	Force Grayscale: Your backend must convert all body text to 100% K (Black) via LaTeX color profiles (<code>[gray]{xcolor}</code>).
Lulu	Weird Page Counts. For certain bindings (saddle stitch), page counts <i>must</i> be divisible by 4.	The "Ghost Page" Logic: If a user submits a 38-page book for saddle-stitch, auto-insert 2 blank pages at the end to hit 40.
Barnes & Noble	Cover Templates. Their hardcovers have different "turn-in" (wrap-around) measurements than KDP.	Dynamic Templates: You need a separate "Cover Calculator" for B&N Press.

2. The "Dust Jacket" Problem (Hardcovers)

Amazon KDP mostly does **Case Laminate** (hardcover with printed image). IngramSpark and B&N offer **Dust Jackets** (paper wrapper with flaps).

- **The Constraint:** A Dust Jacket PDF is huge. It has two extra panels (the flaps) that fold inside.

- **The "God-Tier" Solution:**

- Add a toggle: **"Generate Dust Jacket Template?"**
- If Yes: The PDF canvas width expands by ~7 inches (3.5" per flap).
- *Why:* Authors struggle massively to calculate flap width + spine + bleed. If you automate this, you win their loyalty forever.

3. The "Library" Standard (PDF/X-1a)

Amazon is lenient; it accepts messy PDFs. IngramSpark is strict. It demands **PDF/X-1a:2001** compliance.

- **What it is:** A subset of PDF that bans transparency, enforces CMYK, and embeds all fonts.
- **The Implementation:**
 - You are already using pandoc + xelatex.
 - To get PDF/X-1a, you must add specific **Ghostscript** post-processing to your backend pipeline.
 - *Command:* `gs -dPDFX -sDEVICE=pdfwrite ...`
 - *Why:* If you don't do this, users will get opaque error messages like "Transparency Group Present" and blame you.

4. The "Universal" Trim Sizes

To be safe across **all** platforms (KDP, Ingram, Lulu, B&N), you should restrict users to these "Safe Harbor" sizes. If they pick these, they can upload the *same* PDF to every platform without re-formatting.

1. **5 x 8 inches** (Fiction standard)
2. **5.5 x 8.5 inches** (The "Goldilocks" size)
3. **6 x 9 inches** (Trade standard)
4. **7 x 10 inches** (Textbooks/Tech)
5. **8 x 10 inches** (Children's/Art - *Note: 8.5x11 is standard in US, but 8x10 is safer globally*)

Avoid: 5.25 x 8 (Amazon loves it, others hate it).

5. The Strategy: "Export Targets"

Don't just have a "Download PDF" button. Have an **"Export Target"** dropdown in your CompileShell.

- **Target: Amazon KDP**
 - *Logic:* RGB images allowed (Amazon converts well), slightly tighter gutter allowed.
- **Target: IngramSpark / Global**

- *Logic*: Force CMYK conversion, enforce PDF/X-1a, strictly check ISBN placement.
- **Target: Digital / Web**
 - *Logic*: RGB colors preserved, hyperlinks clickable (print PDFs often kill links), lower file size (72dpi images vs 300dpi).

6. Technical Checklist for the Backend

- **Barcode Zones**: Ingram requires a precise 1.75" x 1" white box on the back cover bottom-right. Your cover generator must automatically mask this area so users don't put text there.
- **Total Ink Coverage (TIC)**: Printing presses reject files where ink density > 240%. Your backend needs a "Pre-flight" check to warn users if their images are too dark/saturated.

Would you like the specific Ghostscript command to convert your XeLaTeX output into Ingram-compliant PDF/X-1a?